



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 23

MICHIGAN

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Michigan's family courts and child-welfare system.

91

MICHIGAN FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
118 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 16
MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF
PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 6, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

34 OF 83

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

MICHIGAN AT A GLANCE.

Across 91 Michigan families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 118 90 of 91 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$107,250 median across 40 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 16 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 47.3% 44.0% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 91	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.3	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 90 of 91	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 34

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Michigan families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02

THE COST OF MICHIGAN FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	55	\$18,000	\$60,564	\$3,331,000
Lost Wages	42	\$10,000	\$69,845	\$2,933,500
Other Court Fees	30	\$875	\$23,832	\$714,951
Therapy / Evaluations	36	\$1,750	\$7,201	\$259,231
Reunification Services	30	\$76	\$5,788	\$173,651
GAL Fees	30	\$1	\$6,093	\$182,802
Asset Loss ¹	40	\$40,000	—	—
Median Family Burden (40 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$107,250	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$40,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		16	1.3 yrs
Mean months lost		40	3.3 yrs
Total across all families		2,217	184.8 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · MICHIGAN

Most families documenting in Michigan are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		47	52%
Not provided		21	23%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		9	10%
Case closed: within last 2 years		8	9%
Not in court but still affected		3	3%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		42	46%
Family Court Only		30	33%
Unknown		10	11%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		8	9%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		1	1%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		21	23%
Over 10 years		16	18%
5 – 10 years		16	18%
3 – 5 years		12	13%
6 months – 1 year		11	12%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		22	24%
Visitation Only		17	19%
50/50 Joint		14	15%
Children in Foster Care		12	13%
Full Custody		11	12%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Oakland		10	11%
Wayne		9	10%
Montcalm		4	4%
Macomb		4	4%
Washtenaw		3	3%
Kalamazoo		3	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		26	29%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		17	19%
Other: (Short answer)		11	12%
Medical CPS (Medical Child Abuse allegations, disagreement with doctors)		8	9%
High Conflict Divorce		4	4%

04 PARENT VOICES — MICHIGAN

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Michigan comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



They have ripped 3 very important years from me and my girls after a decade long with my abuser I was finally leaving and instead of helping me they took my kids because of his actions this has been devastating and will never be the same they have my me feel completely defeated [...]

— KELLY

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

My husband recorded my daughter through the bathroom window at my home. I called Ashley child advocacy center and also took her for a forensic interview. At that time we both did a police interview. I picked up my husband after work and took him to turn in his phone and [...]

— MICHIGAN PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM MICHIGAN

They stole my children and gave my ex sole physical and legal custody. No convictions or abuse allegations or charges. NO CPS involvement

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed the fabric of my family and my whole existence! 5 children ripped from their mother!

— AMYJO

Ripped us apart and traumatized my children

— SIERRA

Ripped my family in half. Sold two kids to abusers Jason and Jessica Klimp.

— STACY

Destroyed normalcy for our children Not listened to the children Traumatized us Taken all our money

— LAUREN

I have spent 19 years in fear because of the wrong doing. After they terminated my rights I was diagnosed as ptsd and severe agoraphobia. Since my kids turned 18 they have come home but cps still terrorizes me for my five younger children. Threats of using my 19 year old case to [...]

— AMY

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system has traumatized us, used us, abused us, ignored us, and tried to break down our mental well-being.

— STACEY

Traumatized my children, which led to psychological behaviors occurring after removal, depriving me of the right to visitation only allowing my husband to visit our children for 3 months when this case first opened, due process violations, destroyed my childrens bond with their [...]

— KIRSTIE

It has stolen our time and destroyed our belief in this country, while it shattered our voices leaving us to pick up the pieces.

— STACI

The CPS supervisor lied and medically kidnapped both of my grandchildren because she has a vendetta against disabled veteran families

— TERI

in suspending my parenting time for "risk of harm" they created ongoing and irreparable harm to my children. The judgement of divorce which was meant to stabilize my children's lives was dismantled by a GAL with unchecked authority, a loophole in the legal system to punish and [...]

— AMANDA

The system and destroyed my family, my bond with my children and had a court ordered divorce.

— KAYC

<https://voiceofdetroit.net/2016/05/01/hearing-on-disabled-abused-child-may-2-why-does-judge-martha-snow-endanger-janna-jail-mom/>

— SHANNON (DEBACKER)

“CPS didn’t just take my children—it fractured our family, leaving behind a pain that reshaped every part of our lives. We’re still fighting to heal from something that changed us forever.”

— SAMANTHA

It destroyed my family. My children are not even allowed to see each other now.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



I am a mother who is only allowed to raise half my children, because of "predicted harm"

— AMBER

Has destroyed my relationship with my children, my community, and has breached my constitutional rights even though I proven that mother is an unfit mother.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

If I were to describe what is being done to these children and families in the system in one word, it would be torture

— SYDNEY

This system did not just break apart my marriage, it destabilized my entire family by turning loss into years of financial pressure, legal battles, and emotional damage. It has strained my relationship with my children, stripped away stability, and made rebuilding feel like [...]

— PAUL

The system enabled domestic violence and terror upon me and the kids and it severed my bond with my twins.

— STEPHANIE

They have failed us. Always gave the mother what she requested. Ignored emotional abuse to the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Emotional strain , separation between siblings in the home, cost me my job ,my rights .

— DAVID

Raped me of the opportunity to be a mother & Deprived my children of growing up with a mom, and made me cold and dead behind the eyes.

— CHRISTINA

Destroyed my family, lost my home and has ruined her siblings relationships

— DEAN

Erased my motherhood and all my children's loving memories

— BRANDEE

Completely destroyed my home, my life, my kids and family irreparably

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system did not benefit our family in any way because they medically kidnapped my granddaughter on false allegations and coercion! We are a disabled veteran household with autism in our family history and CPS used everything against us without proof!

— TERI

Gave me PTSD, financial drain, depression, anxiety, and psychological trauma to my minor children

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Denied me and my girls the right to speak for ourselves and only allowed the opinion of my wealthy ex to speak and make false allegations.

— LESLIE

My son's mom basically kidnapped my son, moved about six states away. Press false charges against me to keep me away from my son even longer so she would have full custody.. I went in to court with an attorney within 10 minutes I don't even know what happened it happened so fast [...]

— JOHN

The system didn't just fail to protect my children, it became part of the harm by rewarding delay, conflict, and procedure over stability and safety. Instead of reducing trauma, it created and prolonged it.

— KELLY

Evil trauma to my entire family

— WILHELMINA

STOLEN TIME AWAY FROM MY CHILDREN, PAYING CHILD SUPPORT AND STILL PAYING FOR MORE THAN 50% OF EVERYTHING FOR CHILDREN, NOT BEING ABLE TO COMMUNICATE DIRECTLY WITH THE CHILDREN FOR DAYS AND WEEKS AT A TIME.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have been followed, harassed, tracked, mail has been stolen so I didn't show up to a unknown court date, purjuy, alienation, identity theft has occurred, my house has been broken into and have been watch, Judge said she would not look at all the evidence of a disabled child [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have lost my job over false allegations. I have to homeschool my son now. My house is up for sale so I can try to get counsel

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system has failed my family, destroyed our lives and made me homeless.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my family, our bonds. Ive lost everything more than once now Pain beyond measure..... I hate opening my eyes everyday knowing I have to live another day like this.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It broke us physically and mentally. I'm advocating for my daughter Tichina Sanders. This is her story. Cps fabricated lies and the judge went along with it by not looking at her evidence.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We will never get back what we lost.

— ROBERTA

Years of mistreatment and abuse from the system has caused major issues within my family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Navigating this process has placed prolonged emotional and financial strain on my family while we work toward reunification, stability, and a sense of normalcy for my children.

— MOLLY

I am bankrupt and hardly surviving, 8 years and I am financially ruined and every bit of savings and retirement gone. I thank god my children are safe with me-due to a violent attack and the other parent the attacker-family court is now forcing visits or jail for me. I am [...]

— KERRY

The system has literally made me terrified of being a parent.

— JOSHUA

Created years of psychological and emotional damage, financial damage

— MATT

It caused me such emotional harm and mental health issues

— CHRIS

The system has exploited my mental health crisis for funding, along with keeping their caseloads up.

— KAYC

68 Michigan parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 48 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — MICHIGAN

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Michigan families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

They have ripped 3 very important years from me and my girls after a decade long with my abuser I was finally leaving and instead of helping me they took my kids because of his actions this has been devastating and will never be the same they have my me feel completely defeated not to mention the false positive drug screen I had that set me back 6 months

— KELLY

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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Ripped my family in half. Sold two kids to abusers Jason and Jessica Klimp.

— STACY

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

My husband recorded my daughter through the bathroom window at my home. I called Ashley child advocacy center and also took her for a forensic interview. At that time we both did a police interview. I picked up my husband after work and took him to turn in his phone and interview. At first he denied. At that time my daughter (15) was unsure if he did it and he had a believable story. He stayed roughly 1 month until he admitted and moved out. I called the police and he turned himself in. The court opened a case and stated he was the respondent. The day of court I became the respondent, got placed in front of an attorney with a list of allegations, and sat in front of the judge. I had asked in court if my husband could live in the apartment in the barn with no unsupervised contact and no access to the house (I was a stay at home mom and home schooled at the time) they took my children that day and placed them in kinship care. They claimed mental and emotional neglect and academic neglect (3 of my children have IEPs and have been in public school and continue to fall behind. I was a substitute and decided to home school this year. Since they have court ordered my children to return to public school). This story goes on. This is just day one. This has been awful and has destroyed my family in ways I can't explain. I lost my husband one day and two days later had my children ripped. I'm so tired and broken. They are home but so lost. My son almost got admitted inpatient psychiatric because separation anxiety is so bad he has become unsafe. He is 7 years old. My life is turned upside down and they still have jurisdiction and FRP is involved. Next hearing is beginning of March.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— LAUREN

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Traumatized my children, which led to phycological behaviors occuring after removal, depriving me of the right to visitation only allowing my husband to visit our children for 3 months when this case first opened, due process violations, destroyed my childrens bond with their biological parents and intentionally kept them in a foster home for an extensive amount of time , prolonged reunification so that my children build a strong connection with this foster family and then when my children were given back, they came and removed them 3 months later and arrested my husband . That night my entire family was ripped away from me

— KIRSTIE

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I have lost my job over false allegations. I have to homeschool my son now. My house is up for sale so I can try to get counsel

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— CHRIS

The system has exploited my mental health crisis for funding, along with keeping their caseloads up.

— KAYC

The system has made my family estranged and kept my daughter's separated and my 5 year old isolated

— JENNIFER

This System Destroys families and tries to Ruin Family Bonds!

— DANIELLE

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Raped, convicted, drained, and Murdered the future for the next generation of family.

— EMILY

Constant constitutional violations and extortion

— DAVID

I've been financially and emotionally destroyed by a system that overlooked evidence of harm to my child, dismissed my appeal, and continues to prevent fair, neutral review."

— AMY

Creating orders with no factual evidence.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I'm being set up to become a payer to the Title IV-D system. My ex made false allegations, sent multiple death threats and still has more custody than me. I make more money so guess who doesn't get to see their kid.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My children and I had such a joyfilled relationship and they trusted that I would protect them after what happened. I told them the courts would see the truth, we just had to trust the process, and that everything would be OK. It wasn't. Everything was taken from us. That was nearly nine years ago and I have not been able to see my children nor do I know where they were moved even though my ex had multiple CPS records and incidents known by therapists. The children lost their mother, their siblings, their maternal family, their home, their trusted doctors and other professionals, their trusted friends, their financial assets, their safety, and their hopes and dreams. Me too. They do not know their mother has never stopped fighting for them. They do not know how much they are missed by their mother, her family, or their friends. I do not know if they are happy or if they have true personal agency. They were robbed of their childhood. I was robbed of motherhood. I do not even know if they are alive. No mother ought ever bear such agony.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Set my family aside for now and almost killed me I can't understand this broken system taht we set is against us.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Coercion, harassment, intimidation, walked in our home without a warrant unlawfully, lies, death, newborn injuries in state care

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Since 2020, the family court system has upheld an ex parte custody order issued while I was in rehab, maintaining supervised visitation and imposing over \$20,000 in child support debt despite my zero income and finalized divorce in 2021. This outcome reflects a system that protects wealth and retaliation over rehabilitation, fairness, and the long-term emotional well-being of my children.

— JENNY

Lost my job, forced to sell our home, lost our property in a storage unit, they kidnapped our newborn and labeled us dangerous to him, can see 4 out of 5 of my kids, wife has passed away now from a heart attack from postpartum

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Judge Cholack pushing off motions to other people of the court to handle it because he doesn't want too. It failed to see the narcissistic ways of my ex and the damage he has created to my daughter. Proof and evidence all ignored. Motions signed and ignored by ex. Haven't spoke to my daughter since may 2nd 2025

— HOLLY

Tore us apart when we needed the help. Lied on circumstances to my children and I. Used us for their game of monopoly. Constantly refused me access to information.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Enabled a controlling, abusive man to continue escalating his bad behavior through lack of any form of accountability and by using our property and son as leverage.

— ALLEY

This almost killed me AND my child! I've lost trust and respect for the people involved in making and allowing this to happen to us, and allowing it to go on so long!

— TIFFANY

The system has broken my family, my daughters paternal family hasn't been able to see her in 10+ months has destroyed my life financially, destroyed my parents financially, has emotionally destroyed not only me but my parents, my nieces, my brother and sister in law. This has caused devastation within our entire family

— NICK

The System has put my child in the hands of an abusive parent. The system believes fairness for the parents over my child's safety and multiple sources of proof and professionals input.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I'm trying to fight filed DOJ complaint and the consistuinal violations I don't get to see my only son and I'm a good man. No record she has tried to has me jailed caused me to loose my job of 24 years with abuse of process with her scum lawyer! I'm trying to sue then but she has hired two lawyers against me now trying to damage my integrity an my life has been ruined. I'm sick what she has done to me please help me please

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Financially devastating.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

68 full approved Michigan comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Michigan report comes from Michigan respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Michigan — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 91 Michigan families reporting here are not the universe of Michigan families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

STANDWITHMEG.COM | COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE.